Academic writing

Sabrina Karim

Department of English

American International University-Bangladesh

Academic Writing (pg 1 & 2)



PURPOSE OF ACADEMIC WRITING IS: TEACHING, LEARNING, TESTING, SEMINARS AND CONFERENCES.



TARGET AUDIENCE: TEACHERS, PEERS, EXAMINERS, SUPERVISORS AND ACADEMICS



ACADEMIC WRITING IS CLEAR AND CONCISE



IT REQUIRES EXTENSIVE READING AND CRITICAL THINKING

Academic Writing (pg 1 & 2)

- Academic Writing is:
  - Formal
  - Impersonal
  - Objective
  - Cautious
  - Complex
  - Precise and accurate
  - Uses standard style of Citations/Referencing



Make the Language Formal 1 (Pg: 78 & 79)

- 1. Avoid personal pronouns (I/me/we)
- Example:
  - I think social media helps you a lot.
  - Social Media helps people a lot.
- 2. Omit contractions and abbreviations (where necessary)
- Example:
  - We’re hoping to travel abroad.
  - We are hoping to go abroad.

Make the Language Formal 2 (Pg: 78 & 79)

- 3. Make your language objective
  - Example:
    - I think women are not interested in technology.
    - Recent trends of buying computers suggest that women are not quite interested in technology.
- 4. Avoid/Omit emotive expressions
  - Example:
    - Sadly, he failed.
    - He failed in this course.
- 5. Omit direct questions
  - Example
    - Did you know, 60% people of Dhaka city eats outside on weekends.
    - 60% people of Dhaka city eats outside on weekends.

Avoid Colloquial Language

- Avoid colloquial language. Unless a writing assignment explicitly states that a conversational tone is appropriate, write using more formal language.
  - Original: It was so noisy, I couldn't hear myself think.
  - Revised: The noise made concentrating difficult.
  - Original: What a mess! The work could not be done
  - Revised: The situation was too chaotic for completing the task
  - Original: I worked hard on the assignment because I didn't want to screw up.
  - Revised: I worked diligently on the assignment because I wanted to succeed.

Omit Contractions

You’re	They’re	He’d
We’d	I’m	Even the abbreviations like AIUB

Using Objective Language pg 83,84 & 85

also called impersonal writing

places emphasis on information and arguments

uses third person pronouns (e.g. it / he / she / they / them)

How to make language more objective? Pg 83, 84 & 85

- use passive
- focus on evidence

  e.g. findings/ data/ research/figures
- use evidence from sources
- use impersonal phrases (i.e. phrases with ‘It’ and ‘ There’)
- uses hedges /cautious langguage (to soften the language)

Cautious Language or hedging Pg 80 & 81

- An important feature of academic writing is the concept of cautious language, often called “hedging” or “vague language“.
- In other words, it is necessary to make decisions about your stance on a particular subject, or the strength of the claims you are making.

Using Cautious Words
Pg 80 & 81

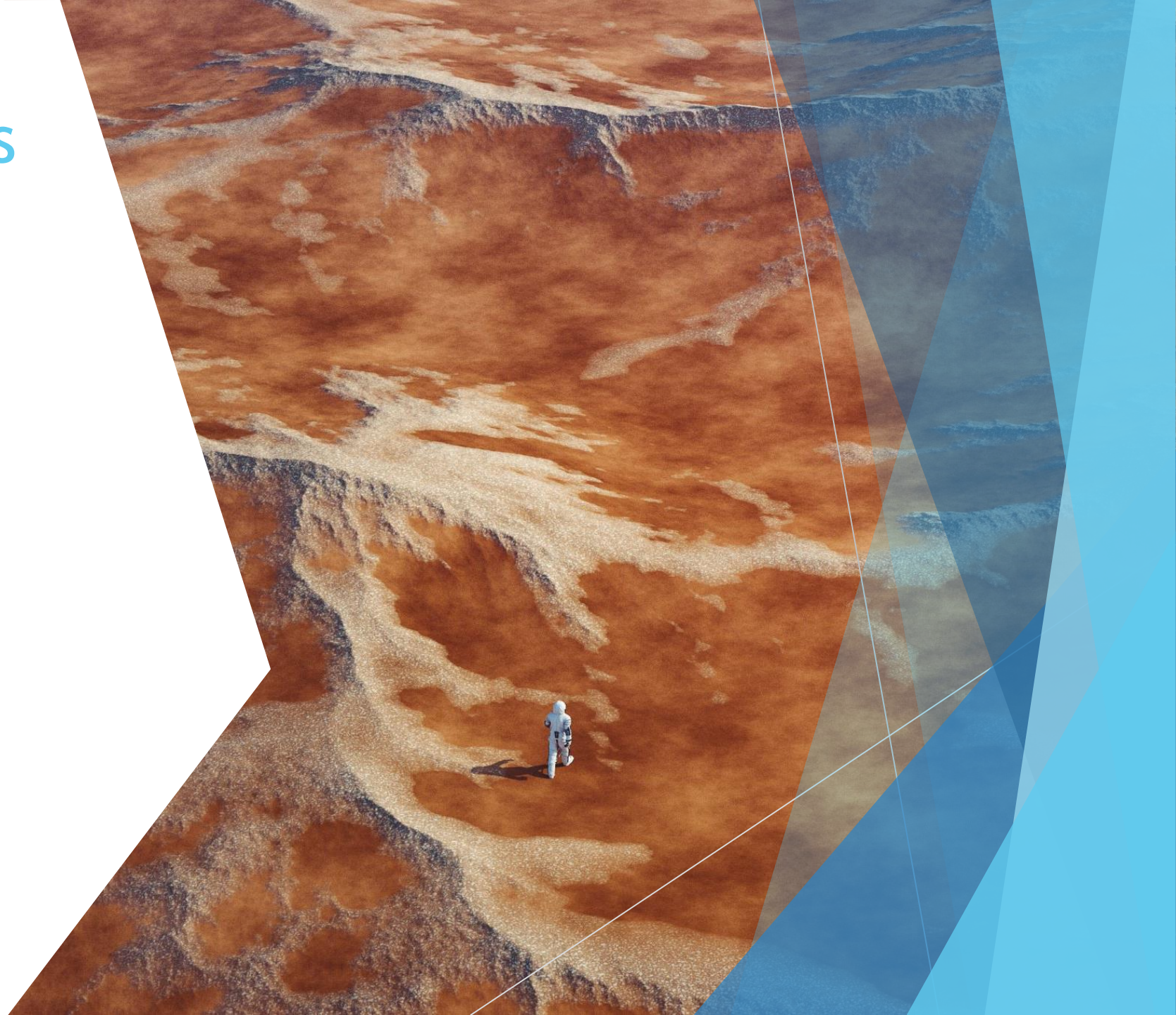
- Introductory verbs: e.g. seem, tend, look like, appear to be, think, believe, doubt, be sure, indicate, suggest
- Certain lexical verbs: e.g. believe, assume, suggest
- Certain modal verbs: e.g. will, must, would, may, might, could
- Adverbs of frequency: e.g. often, sometimes, usually
- Modal adverbs: e.g. certainly, definitely, clearly, probably, possibly, perhaps, conceivably,

Using Cautious Words
Pg: 80 & 81

- Modal adjectives: e.g. certain, definite, clear, probable, possible
- Modal nouns: e.g. assumption, possibility, probability
- That clauses e.g. It could be the case that . e.g. It might be suggested that . e.g. There is every hope that .
- To-clause + adjective: e.g. It may be possible to obtain . e.g. It is important to develop . e.g. It is useful to study .

Exercise Cautious Language

- 1. Playing violent video games causes more aggression, bullying, and fighting.
- 2. Mars is the focus of much scientific study and the foremost planet for human colonisation.



Answers Cautious Language

1. It is assumed that playing violent video games may cause more aggression, bullying, and fighting.

2. Mars is certainly the focus of much scientific study and often considered the foremost planet for human colonisation.

Using Language Precisions/Accuracy Pg 81, 84, 85 & 86

- Use precise and accurate words other than a lot explanatory words:
- Example:
  - The burgers, sandwiches and french-fries sold in stores of Dhaka are reasons behind growing up diagnostic centers of the city.
  - burgers, sandwiches and french-fries : Fast Food
  - Stores of Dhaka: many fast-food stores
  - Growing-up: increase
  - Diagnostic centers : increased amount of diagnostic centers

	Informal (Incorrect)	Formal (Correct)
Contractions	The storm wasn't severe.	The storm was not severe.
Phrasal verbs	The company wants to pull out of the deal.	The company intends to exit the deal.
Slang	Kids should exercise more.	Children should exercise more.
Texting acronyms	The problem needs to be solved ASAP.	The problem requires urgent attention.
Cliché	It goes without saying that protecting the environment is important.	Obviously, protecting the environment is important.
Personal pronouns	You have many course options at State University.	Students have many course options at State University.
Rhetorical questions	Why are vaccines a controversial issue?	Vaccines are a controversial issue.
Judgemental or emotive language	I believe that... A fantastic development...	Evidence shows... A very positive development...
Absolute statements	Germans are punctual.	Germans tend to be punctual.

Keep Practicing